

Chapter 4

Planning

The importance of carefully planning a group cannot be overemphasized. According to Conyne and Diederich (2014), "Planning a group is often one of the areas not given enough attention in practice" (p. 25). Corey (2012) states, "If you want a group to be successful, you need to devote considerable time to planning. In my view planning should begin with the drafting of a written proposal" (p. 80). We agree that there are *two aspects of planning: pregroup planning* and *session planning*. Both are very important. Conyne and Diederich (2014) have an excellent section on planning guidelines based on the Association for Specialists in Group Work's *Best Practice Guidelines 2007 Revisions* (Thomas & Pender, 2008).

Pregroup Planning

Many groups are not successful due to too little emphasis on pregroup planning. Gladding (2012) points out the necessity of pregroup planning: "The dynamics of a group begin before the group ever convenes" (p. 52). In Chapters 1 and 2, we discussed several considerations for the formation of a group: size of the group, whether it should have open or closed membership, how long sessions should last, and where it should meet. Four additional decisions to be made when establishing a group include the following:

1. For how many sessions will the group meet?
2. When will the group meet?
3. Who should the members be?
4. How will the members be screened?

For How Many Sessions Will the Group Meet?

Many groups are established for a certain length of time. For instance, parenting, childbirth, assertiveness-training, certain growth and therapy, and many education groups are scheduled to meet for a specified number of sessions. Counseling, therapy, growth, task, and support groups sometimes begin with no set number of sessions planned. Usually it is best to set a limit because it gives members an idea of how long they have to complete any personal work. Another option is to allow members to determine the number of sessions once the group has been meeting for a while. Often, the number of sessions is dictated by other considerations, such as the length of a school term, the leader's availability, the needs of the population being served, or the amount of educational information to be covered.

When Will the Group Meet?

Two factors must be considered: time of day and frequency of meetings. Ideally, the meeting time will not conflict with members' other activities. If the setting for the group is an agency, school, or hospital, the choice of meeting time should cause as little disruption as possible to the daily routine. Choice of meeting time is especially important in a school, where the students come from classes. The leader will want to make sure the same class is not missed on a regular basis by having the group rotate periods each week. For groups in an elementary setting, a counselor may be inclined to always have the group meet during recess. Be cautious of this in that students may not want to always give up their recess time.

The members' schedules also must be considered when setting the time. If the members work, perhaps the evening is best, or maybe even early morning or noon. For groups in a residential center—such as a prison, hospital, or detention center—a careful examination of the daily routine is helpful. Beginning leaders often make the mistake of planning a group without fully considering the many factors that might make the meeting time inconvenient.

The leader's schedule is also important; she must always be available to lead the group, and some times and days are better than others. Days when the leader tends to be very busy with such things as staff meetings or intakes should be avoided. In the case of therapy groups, it is too taxing for the leader to lead one group right after another. Ideally, any therapy group leader would lead no more than one group a day; the maximum should be three.

Besides deciding on the best time to meet, the leader is usually the one to decide how often the group will meet. Some groups meet daily; others meet twice a week, once a week, once every two weeks, or once a month. The frequency of meetings depends on the kind of group, its purpose, and the availability of members and the leader. There is no set formula for how often a group should meet, but the leader must ensure that the meetings are properly spaced. It is important that the group neither meet so often nor so infrequently as to defeat the overall purpose.

Who Should the Members Be?

Any time a group is being formed, a number of considerations arise regarding its membership (Corey, 2012). Once the population to be served is determined

(schoolchildren, hospital patients, prisoners, clients of a mental-health center, or interested persons in a community), the leader should decide whether the entire population will automatically constitute the membership or whether the members will volunteer or be selected. For example, in an orientation group at a university residence hall, will the group consist of all 15 new students in a wing, or will it include only those who want to be in a group? In a hospital unit for psychiatric patients, will the group be for everyone, or will only selected patients be allowed? There are no absolute guidelines for deciding whom to include; usually the purpose of the group, time constraints, and setting will help the leader decide how to limit membership.

Another consideration is whether to place members who are very different in age or background in the same group. Certainly, multicultural issues need to be considered when selecting members. In schools, counselors have to decide whether to include students from the same grade or from different grades. Also, school counselors need to decide if the groups should consist of the same or mixed genders. In various hospital situations, patients in the same unit often include young and old people or people with varying educational or socioeconomic backgrounds. Sometimes mixing ages or backgrounds is beneficial; at other times, it can be detrimental. If the leader were planning a group for the unemployed, it would not be beneficial to place college-educated individuals and high school dropouts in the same group because their needs would differ. In a marital-problems group, mixing ages and backgrounds would probably prove beneficial because members might benefit from hearing different views and ideas. Because each group is different, we are not saying that certain groups should have certain members, but it is very important that the leader consider these different variables when selecting members of a group.

How Will the Members Be Screened?

Closely related to questions about composition of membership are decisions about screening members. One of the biggest problems faced by counselors in agencies and institutions is that administrators do not let leaders select the members; therefore, groups are often conducted with members who should not be in the group. We encourage you to lobby hard for the right to screen your members. *Screening is essential because not everyone is appropriate for every group.*

Sonstegard and Bitter (2004) present a different point of view from most others who write about group counseling:

> Adlerians typically reject the idea of screening. The process seems more designed for the protection of the therapist than the facilitation of the group. Too often, prescreening eliminates from the group the very person or people who could use the group experience: the disruptive, the self-absorbed, and the isolated. (p. 19)

Although we see some merit in their point of view, it has been our experience that some members can ruin groups, especially if an inexperienced leader is in charge. Even with experienced leaders, negative, hostile, or inappropriate members can cause other members to stop coming to a potentially beneficial group.

We encourage leaders not to sacrifice an entire group trying to help one individual and agree with Corey, Corey, Callahan, and Russell (2010) who write: "Leaders need to keep in mind that all groups are not appropriate for all people" (p. 47).

With some groups, screening is either unnecessary or only slightly beneficial. As Corey (2012) says, "The key point is that screening needs to be done within the context of the type of group that a practitioner is offering. Whether a client is to be included or excluded has much to do with the purposes of the group" (p. 83). For education, discussion, and task groups, screening may not be necessary.

When screening is both possible and desirable, the leader has several procedural options.

The Personal Interview The best screening method, though the most time consuming, is the personal interview. It allows the leader to assess most easily the appropriateness of the member for the group, and it gives the leader a chance to make contact with potential members. The leader has an opportunity to inform the prospective member about the group's content, process, membership, rules, and so forth. Also, the personal interview gives potential members the chance to ask questions about the group. Listed are a number of questions that can be asked in a personal interview or on a screening form:

- Why do you want to be in this group?
- What are your expectations of the group?
- Have you ever been in a group before? If so, what was it like?
- What concerns do you want help with?
- Is there anyone with whom you would not want to be in a group?
- How do you think you can contribute to the group?
- Do you have any questions about the group or the leader?

Individual contact with the potential member It is important for the leader to make this experience more than just a question-and-answer session. The leader should realize that the interview is the beginning of his relationship with the member. He will want to use many of the same skills used in an individual counseling session—attending, listening, and some probing—without letting the interview become a counseling session. During the screening interview, the leader can explain how the group will be conducted, any rules, and other relevant information. If the group is a counseling or therapy group, the leader can tell the member about the theories that may be used. Screening for counseling and therapy groups allows the leader to determine if the person's needs can best be met by group or individual counseling. Some leaders show a videotape of a group so the prospective member can see what the group will be like.

Written Screening Another method of screening is to have prospective members complete a written form. At a minimum, the form will include biographical information such as: age, grade level completed, sex, marital status, living situation, age of children, diagnosis, length of illness, and any important medical

information. When basing choices on written material only, the leader will want to include pertinent questions. Questions that are sometimes overlooked include the candidate's availability for meetings and whether the candidate needs child-care and transportation.

The questions outlined for the personal interview can be used as part of a written screening form. Naturally, the questions asked depend on the purpose of the group. If the topics to be covered are sensitive ones—such as sex, death, divorce, or religion—the leader may want to list them and ask prospective members to comment on how they feel about talking about those subjects. Some leaders ask members to write a brief autobiography as a way to help with screening. The key to effective screening is to find out the information needed to form a group of members who can share and learn together.

Screening by Referral Sources Another type of screening occurs when the leader informs possible referral sources, such as teachers or administrators, other therapists, or hospital staff, about the group, its purpose, and the kind of member sought. These people, in a sense, do the screening by telling appropriate potential members of the availability of the group. The leader who uses this method of screening will want to make sure that those making referrals fully understand the purpose of the group and the kind of members desired.

Screening by Using a Comprehensive Group Program A leader conducting several groups in the same setting—such as in a prison, hospital, company, or school—can screen by assigning members to any one of the groups. Assigning members according to their knowledge, age, experience, or some personality characteristic often increases the likelihood of the group being valuable to the members. The leader can also sort members according to their interaction style or level of mental health. The leader may choose to place some highly verbal members in a group with some non-talkers. There really are no absolute guidelines for making these decisions because each situation and purpose is so different. The main thing to realize is that these kinds of screening decisions can be instrumental in enhancing positive therapeutic forces.

If the leader does not select a member, she may want to meet with that member and discuss options for other groups or individual counseling. This depends on the setting and the situation, but it is important for the leader to be sensitive to anyone who may feel rejected by the screening process.

Screening After the Group Has Begun Corey, Corey, Callahan, and Russell (2010) suggest conducting a preliminary group session for potential members, especially in therapy groups, to give participants a chance to see if being in a group is the best decision for them. Also it gives the leader a chance to see the potential members in a group situation. There may be times when a leader needs to screen members even after the group has begun. The leader may state in the first session that after the group meets for a couple of times, he plans to meet with each member to discuss their ongoing participation in the group. This kind of screening can be an excellent way to handle the formation of groups

when there is a need to screen out some members who are not right for the group.

Another kind of screening that can be done after the group has been meeting for a few weeks is to have the members write a couple of pages on why the group is important and what they want to get from the group. The leader stipulates that only those who complete the assignment can be in the group for the remaining sessions. The leader would use this kind of screening only when wanting to weed out those who are not committed to working in the group. In Chapter 12, we discuss further when and how to screen out members during the middle sessions.

Additional Considerations for Pregroup Planning

The leader will want to ascertain whether any additional materials are needed for the group, any resource people must be contacted, or any permission forms must be signed. School policy often requires that school counselors have permission forms signed by parents or guardians. A simple form describing the group and its purpose usually is sufficient. It may also be useful to consider whether any kind of oral or written contract from members is desirable.

Big-Picture Planning

Another part of pregroup planning is what we call *big-picture planning*. By this, we mean thinking about all the possible topics that need to be covered or could be covered. Too often, leaders think only about the first session and not the overall picture of what needs to be covered during the life of the group. We suggest the leader first list the possible topics and then later put them in some possible order to be covered during the beginning, early middle, and middle stages of the group. A good leader makes an extensive list of possible topics and then prioritizes the topics to gain a better idea of what is important to cover and what can be omitted. The examples below are lists of possible topics that would then be prioritized.

Anger Management Group (Meeting for Six Sessions)

Where anger comes from

Who or what situations members think cause them to get angry

How different theories look at anger

REBT self-talk; TA child ego-state

Anger at parents

Guilt in regard to anger

How members currently deal with anger

Current anger

Past anger

Anger at siblings, friends, others

Anger as a habit

Better ways to handle anger

Anger as a cover-up for hurt

What members learned about anger as they were growing up

Divorce Group (Meeting for Eight Sessions)

Children
Dating
Sex
Anger
Guilt, hurt, blame/fault
Loneliness
Unfinished business
Self-esteem
Money
Remarriage
History of other relationships
What can be learned from the marriage experience
Fears
Feelings of failure

After making the list, the leader considers which topics should be addressed in the beginning stage, which ones should be brought up later, which ones need be only briefly mentioned, and which ones may be unnecessary altogether. This kind of planning definitely helps the leader have a better understanding of what he perceives the group will cover. This big-picture understanding aids the leader during the first few sessions when members clarify how the group can be helpful and which topics may be covered.

For most groups, considerable time should be spent doing big-picture planning. Talking with colleagues about possible topics, reading books and articles on the subject, and gathering information during the screening process can help with big-picture planning. This process needs to be done before the group begins. It also needs to be an ongoing planning activity because the group is always evolving and the need to cover new and different topics often emerges.

Session Planning

Planning a specific session involves deciding on the topics and group activities as well as delegating an approximate amount of time needed for each. Most groups require a good deal of planning, although only a minimum of planning is necessary for certain kinds of counseling, therapy, growth, and support groups after their initial sessions. Minimal planning is necessary when the members come to understand the purpose of their group and arrive at the sessions eager to discuss concerns important to them and relevant to others. Groups require much planning when the members do not tend to bring issues to the group to discuss, but rather respond to exercises and other activities.

Discussion, education, and task groups are often more effective when thoroughly planned. The thoughtful leader can organize the session in a way that makes the group both interesting and productive. In the remainder of this chapter, we discuss the considerations that go into planning an effective group session.

Consider the Stage of the Group

One of the first things to consider when planning a session is whether the session is a first, second, middle, or closing session. During the first session, there are a number

of things that the leader will need to do, such as having members introduce themselves, clarifying the purpose of the group, setting a positive tone for the group, helping members get over any uneasiness, and going over any guidelines or rules for the group. It is important that for most groups, going over the rules should not come at the very beginning. During the closing sessions, the leader should make sure the members are saying and doing the things necessary for ending the group.

Another consideration is for how many more sessions the group will meet. Some groups meet for only one session; planning for that kind of session is obviously different from a group that will meet for 10 weeks. Planning the fifth session when only one session is left is different from planning a fifth session when six more sessions remain.

Plan the Format for the Session

When planning a session, the leader will want to consider the format for the session. Some groups work well with the same format each week; for instance, progress reports, an exercise, discussion, then practicing a new behavior, and closing comments; or sharing personal problems the first hour and then discussing some assigned topic that members were given the week before. For other groups, a varied format seems advantageous because it keeps the interest level high. By a varied format, we mean one session might consist of two different exercises and a discussion; the next session might include a written activity, personal sharing, and then some role-playing practice; and another session might consist of a short film. Doing different things keeps members interested and curious. When planning, the leader should always consider whether the format is becoming stale.

Anticipate Problems When Planning

The leader also needs to anticipate potential problems when planning. For example, if she has asked members to read something for the session, she can anticipate that some members will not have done the reading and can plan ways of processing the material that will not alienate those members. It is sometimes valuable to plan activities with specific members in mind, but it is important to have a backup plan in case those members are absent. In fact, it is always a good idea to have a backup plan in case an activity, exercise, or discussion does not go well.

Planning the Phases of the Session

The leader needs to be aware that each session has three phases: the *warm-up,* or *beginning,* phase; the *middle,* or *working,* phase; and the *closing* phase. During the *warm-up* phase, the leader often has members comment on any thoughts or reactions since the last session. During this phase, the leader also tries to get a sense of the members' energy and interest for the session and any topics or issues they may want to talk about. In the *middle* or *working* phase of the session, members focus on the group's purpose. We call it the middle phase when referring to

an education or discussion group and the working phase for other groups. The *closing* phase is devoted to summarizing and ending the session.

There are specific planning guidelines for each phase of any given session. The process of leading members through each of the phases is covered in great detail in later chapters, but here we want to discuss each phase in regard to planning.

The Beginning Phase

A leader should always plan how to begin a session. The first few minutes are sometimes used to review the previous session or conduct a brief check in regarding any thoughts, interactions, or experiences. Too often, leaders plan a beginning phase that lasts too long. The warm-up phase for most groups is usually less than 10 minutes and should not be more than 15 minutes, except for the first session, where the warm-up phase may need to be longer. With school groups where the sessions are 30 to 40 minutes, counselors will want to plan a brief beginning phase in order to have time for quality interaction during the middle phase.

Some groups require almost no planning of the warming-up time—the members come ready to talk, learn, or work. In other groups, the leader must plan for getting members focused on being in the group. During the beginning phase, the leader plans activities, exercises, or discussions that allow him to assess how members are feeling about being in the group that day. He may plan additional time for warming up if he feels that the group needs more time.

Planning for Introducing a New Member During the Beginning Phase When planning the beginning phase of a session of an open-membership group, the leader will need to allot time and select a method for introducing new members. The leader may either introduce them or have them introduce themselves. Established members can also introduce themselves by sharing how the group has been valuable to them. Chapter 5 contains several examples of how to introduce new members to the group.

Planning for the Energy Level for the Beginning Phase The leader should consider the kind of energy level to use during the beginning phase. Some groups benefit from a high-energy opening, whereas others need a calm opening—the need varies with the members and the purpose of the group. Energy can come from the kind of activities used or from the energy in the leader's voice. One elementary school counselor used a high-energy opening by talking enthusiastically with her attention deficit hyperactive disorder (ADHD) group. She quickly realized this was a mistake; in the next session, she began with a calm voice and a relaxing activity. She found this was much better for these kids. We do want to emphasize that the leader should always consider whether the energy level being used is the best one for the group being led.

The Middle or Working Phase

Planning the middle or working phase is very important because it is the time when meaningful interactions and discussions should take place. Careful planning

can make a big difference in eliminating negative group dynamics and allowing enough time to deal with the purpose of the group and any diversity issues that may be present. We discuss planning concerns for each kind of group. Also, we present sample session plans later in this chapter that should give you a good idea of how to plan for the bulk of the session.

Discussion and Education Groups Planning a discussion or education group session requires the leader to first decide what topics or information to cover, then the order of presentation, and then how the topics should be covered. Additionally, the well-prepared leader will estimate as accurately as possible the amount of time needed for each topic or activity.

A leader has many options for covering a topic. She can give a mini-lecture. She can introduce the topic for discussion and have the members discuss it as a group or in pairs. She can invite a guest speaker or show a DVD. (If a speaker is invited, the leader should inform the speaker of the cultural diversity in the group.) She can use one or more exercises.

Task Groups It is always the leader's responsibility to make each session relevant and productive. Topics and exercises may be useful for some task groups. For example, in a group meeting to improve communications between management and workers, the leader can plan various exercises that help members understand their own communication patterns and style. In a group deciding policies for a new treatment unit, the leader can conduct a brainstorming activity or have the group break into two or three smaller discussion groups.

Support Groups In some support groups, members come eager to share their common concerns—whether it be drugs, divorce, weight problems, or their disability; therefore, little planning is needed. In other support groups, the leader may have to provide topics or exercises that encourage members to share. For instance, in a group for veterans with disabilities, the leader might introduce topics such as how members' disabilities affect family relationships, what the hardest times are, or how to handle stress. In a group for spouses of people with Alzheimer's disease, the leader may introduce topics such as accepting the illness, getting some relief time, or dealing with the loss of the partner as a companion. The important thing to remember in planning a support group is to introduce relevant topics that vary from week to week. If the members are constantly bringing up new and relevant topics, very little planning will be necessary.

Growth or Experiential Groups Because the purpose of growth and experiential groups is to explore some aspect of one's personality, values, or interaction style, it is the leader's responsibility to plan meaningful activities. The leader should plan to focus on either a number of topics or a specific topic and decide whether the group should focus on individuals or on the whole membership. The leader

needs to consider the various group dynamics and therapeutic forces when planning. For instance, if the trust level is low, it would be inadvisable for the leader to plan activities that deal with in-depth personal sharing. He might rather plan trust-building activities. If the group consists of a couple of members who tend to talk all the time, the leader could plan to use some movement exercises and then have members share what they learned or experienced. Also, the leader has to consider any multicultural issues when planning the middle phase of a growth group, because the group's purpose usually is to explore values and attitudes. For instance, in a group that is exploring relationships between men and women, the leader would need to be aware of the different cultural views among the members and allow extra time for discussion of those differences.

Some growth groups are designed to be intense, whereas others are not; it is very important that the leader understands this. The type of activities planned will most definitely affect the level of intensity. The leader needs to give thought as to how heavy or intense the group should be and how to structure the group so that it is maximally beneficial. School groups are not meant to be too heavy, whereas residential treatment groups may get very intense.

Counseling and Therapy Groups The planning of counseling and therapy groups varies greatly. Some require almost no planning because the members are ready, willing, and eager to share their concerns. In other groups, members are in pain, but they need exercises and other activities to encourage them to share. The skilled leader sometimes will choose to cover certain topics, hoping to help one or two specific members. For instance, a leader who knows that a few group members are having trouble dealing with anger may plan an exercise that focuses on anger.

The Closing Phase

Planning the closing phase is crucial; a common mistake is to fail to plan adequately for this phase. Some leaders mistakenly let the clock announce the ending; that is, when the designated time to stop comes around, the group ends. One colleague reported to us that her school group for at risk students was missing something, but she could not quite put her finger on the issue that was holding the group back. As we processed her group, we found out that she was allowing the lunch bell ring to signal the end of the group. When the bell sounded, the students immediately headed for the door. This is problematic. The leader should always allow 3 to 10 minutes for summarizing and processing the session. Leaders should give extra thought to planning the ending of the first and last sessions of any group. Having each person comment on what she has learned or what stood out is a good plan for the closing phase. Other closing activities include discussing briefly the topic for the next session, having members discuss in dyads what they learned, or having each member commit out loud about doing something different during the week.

Sample Session Plans

This section contains sample plans for sessions in different kinds of groups. Note that an estimated time is given for each activity to help the leader gauge the flow of the group. This helps greatly during the session because, otherwise, the leader has little idea whether too much time is being spent on a topic. It is important to allot specific amounts of time for exercises and activities but also to realize *the plan can and often will need to change as the session progresses.* Students at first think we are being rigid about putting the times in a plan, but they quickly see that it does help them when actually leading. The time notations help a leader gauge if he is on schedule. If not on schedule, then he determines if what is happening in the group is equal to or better than what he had planned. The plan and the times are a guide and should be seen only as that—they are not meant to take away any spontaneity from the group that is valuable and in line with the purpose.

As you read through the sample plans, you may see unfamiliar terms. Because our purpose here is to give you an idea of how to plan a session, it is not necessary that you completely understand each activity; these activities are explained in later chapters. We tried to include a variety of techniques and activities to show the many different ways to plan a session. After each plan is a discussion of its features.

Plan 1

The first session of a parenting group consisting of 10 members:

3 min. (7:00 P.M.)	Introductions—round (name, ages of children, why they came to the group).
5 min.	Discuss the group—format, purpose. (Stress that it is mainly an educational and support group, and not a therapy group.) Have members share their needs and any fears or questions about the group. Have them share cultural differences. (Insert the group rules of confidentiality, attendance, no attacking of others.)
2 min.	Sentence completion: The thing I like most about being a parent is _____. The hardest thing about parenting is _____. I get most upset as a parent when _____.
10 min.	Have members share their ideas in large groups. (Use their examples in discussion below.)
15 min.	Discuss Adlerian principles of child behavior. (Use charts and handouts.) All behavior is purposeful. Children are not bad—they are discouraged. Four goals of misbehavior.

5 min. (7:35)	Have members share in triads their thoughts about the Adlerian principles.
10 min.	Discuss in large groups, then continue overview of principles: Parent's reaction to each of the four goals of misbehavior.
20 min.	Focus on the first goal of misbehavior—attention getting. Use short role-plays to demonstrate. Discuss ways to deal with situations.
5 min.	Dyads—discuss this goal in relation to their children and how parents may handle situations differently.
5 min.	Process dyads.
10 min.	Summarize—what stood out, feelings about the group, one thing they plan to do differently. Hand out reading material. Remind them of next meeting time.

In this plan, the introductory exercise is brief because it is an education group lasting only an hour and a half. Also, the leader knows that the members will be interacting in dyads and triads during the sessions, so they will have those opportunities to get to know each other better. The introductions and discussion about the group are useful because they allow members to share some important information and to mention their fears and expectations regarding the group. The plan also includes looking at cultural differences, because that may be a factor in a parenting group. The purpose of the group and the format are clarified during the first 10 minutes. Group rules are minimal, so no specific time is established to review them; they will probably be mentioned when discussing how the group will be conducted. The sentence completion used early in the session gives members a chance to share their views on parenting. The use of sentence stems helps members get more comfortable and "warms them up." The large-group processing allows the leader and other members to hear each member's concerns. In discussing the Adlerian principles, the leader can use examples from the sentence-completion exercise and discussion. The leader chooses to use triads to process the discussion of the principles. Using triads instead of the entire group to discuss some topics enables members to talk more; and often in the early sessions, some members are more comfortable sharing in dyads or triads than in the large group.

The leader varies the format to keep members interested. Also, the leader's plan includes some interesting and immediately useful content that is relevant to the group's purpose. Too often, leaders mistakenly plan first sessions that have very little content; thus, some members do not return. Plan 1 has a good balance between content and process. Because it is the first session, more time than usual is allowed for the summary. Ordinarily, the summary would take 3 to 6 minutes. Remember, time periods are approximate but are necessary to give the leader some idea of how long to stay on any activity.

Plan 2

The second session of a growth and support group for fourth- and fifth-graders who don't seem to make friends easily; there is one new member this week:

5 min.	Introduce new member to the group—have members tell their names and one thing that stood out from last week's session. Comment about the group and its purpose. Also, remind members when they talk to look at others instead of just the leader.
2 min.	Have members list things they can do to make friends.
3 min.	Discuss lists in dyads.
15 min.	List ideas on chalkboard. Discuss the ideas. Role-play some of the ideas. Have each member practice.
3 min.	Have each member tell one thing he or she will try this week.
2 min.	Summarize—each member completes "One thing I learned ..."

In this plan, the leader uses welcoming a new member as a way to review last week's session. The opening segment is short because the session lasts only 30 minutes. Next, the leader uses a written exercise because this is a good way to get the children focused and involved. For the middle phase of the session, the leader has thought of several interesting ways to focus on making friends. The use of dyads helps achieve one purpose of the session, which is learning how to interact with others. Dyads enable members to practice talking with other children. To close the session, the leader plans a simple but focused ending—having members commit to trying something new and asking them to comment on what they learned in the session.

Plan 3

The third session of a 6-week assertiveness-training group with eight members:

10 min. (4:00 P.M.)	Progress reports, observations from the week, questions.
20 min.	Re-enact some "assertiveness" situations from the week (this could last longer if there are a number of situations).
5 min.	Dyads—process thoughts from the re-enactments.
15 min. (4:35)	Present the "broken record" technique: Demonstrate. Practice.
5 min.	Reactions, comments, and questions.

15 min.	Round: How guilty do you feel when you are being assertive? (1–10; 10 = very much) Discuss their numbers and how not to feel guilty—teach REBT. Show ABC model. Write on board their irrational self-talk and then rational self-talk.
5 min. (5:10)	Dyads: Discuss the use of REBT when being assertive.
10 min.	Entire group discussion: Things I plan to try this week regarding being assertive.
5 min.	Summary: What stood out for you today? Any wishes for anyone in the group?

Progress reports are helpful both for the member who shares and for the rest of the members who hear how others are using what they learn in the group. Also, progress reports help members see the continuity and flow of the group experience. Plan 3 includes a review, the introduction of new material, and periods of focus on the past, present, and future. The plan uses a varied format that includes a round, dyads, teaching, demonstrating, practicing, interacting, and committing to trying new behaviors during the coming week. The leader also introduces a theory that members can use during the rest of the sessions. In closing, the leader asks the "wishes for anyone" question so that members can say encouraging things to each other and feel the support of other members; this helps build cohesion in the group.

Plan 4

The third session of a weekly therapy group for outpatients of a mental-health center; the group has six members:

5 min. (4:00 p.m.)	Progress reports—ask about Bob's visit with his mother, Ruth's exercise program, Tandy's contract to talk with two people each day.
5 min.	Ask for thoughts, comments, reactions to the week.
10 min.	Review Ellis's ABC model—use examples from their week.
60 min.	Personal work—do yes/no round of who wants to bring something up; if everyone says no, use backup plan—focus on love relationships: Rate love relationship on a scale of 1 to 10 (10 = great). Ask what keeps it from being a 10 (discussion and personal work should come out of this).

20 min. (5:20)	Introduce TA model if it did not come up during the personal work, or continue the personal work.
10 min.	Share (in triads) reactions to TA model.
5 min.	Summarize—"What stood out?" "How will you use REBT and TA?"
5 min.	Write in journals (journals are left for the leader to read).

In this plan, the leader starts by having specific members report on some of the work they have done in the group. This fosters continuity; also, when members know they are going to report to the group, they seem to commit a bit more to making changes due to the feeling of having to report back. The leader asks about the week to see whether anyone has something to share. This allows members to share positive or negative things that happened. Personal work could be started here, but the leader wants to spend a few minutes reviewing the REBT model and uses the members' comments about the week to show how REBT can be helpful. The review is brief because the leader wants to allow enough time for individual work. In therapy groups, members often come wanting to talk about some concern. The round (an exercise where everyone comments) helps the leader quickly learn how many members have something to discuss. The leader has allowed for an hour or more for personal work if members are so inclined. The leader is anticipating that many of the members will say yes to having things to work on but has a back-up plan just in case.

Frequent Mistakes in Planning

Not Planning

The biggest mistake made in planning is not doing it. Very often, at the end of workshops that we give, group leaders comment that they now realize that problems with their groups stem mostly from not planning. Unfortunately, some professionals still subscribe to the notion that planning detracts from the group. It is very important to understand this is not true. Good planning is the best way to ensure that the session will be valuable to the group members.

Planning Too Much

The opposite of not planning is planning too many activities for the session. Having too many activities planned often results in superficial coverage of several important topics. It is better to cover a few topics in depth than to skim over several. Our students frequently make this mistake because they are afraid members will not talk, so they plan too many topics for the time period allowed. It is

good to have backup plans and additional topics, but it is important for the leader to allow time in his plan to focus on topics long enough that new learning and impact occur.

Irrelevant or Meaningless Content

Too often, leaders choose activities, exercises, or topics that do not interest the members or relate to the purpose of the group. Leaders sometimes use introductory exercises that are irrelevant and, thus, fail to set the appropriate tone. Leaders also introduce topics that relate to only one or two members; this causes the others to lose interest or become resentful. It is absolutely essential that the leader do everything possible to ensure that the session will be relevant and valuable to most or all of the members. The following are examples of *poor* planning.

- For the first session of a weight-loss group, the leader plans 30 minutes on the topic of organic gardening.
- In a group of eight teenagers, the leader plans to focus on how to select the right college to attend, even though only two members are planning to go to college.
- For a 1-hour session for stepparents, the leader plans a 15-minute mini-lecture on society and the family.
- In a group for couples with marital problems, the leader plans 30 minutes on dealing with children. Only two of the five couples have children.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

In video 1.1, the leader planned an opening round of asking members to state their favorite color, which would have been meaningless in this group. This video is an example of planning meaningless activities.

Not Allowing Enough Time for the Group to Have Any Significant Meaning

It is important to realize that the purpose of the group is for members to learn something, gain some personal insights, or accomplish a designated task. A good plan will include time for the group to go to a deep enough level in order for members to gain meaningful experiences from the group sessions.

Inappropriate Exercises

Leaders will sometimes plan an exercise for which members are not ready. For example, during a first or second session, members usually are not ready for an

exercise that involves sharing about sexual concerns, nor are they ready for certain kinds of feedback exercises.

Too Many Exercises

Another mistake leaders make is to plan too many exercises for a given session. This prevents members from having enough time to process and learn from the exercises, thereby robbing them of much of the value of the exercises. Also, the session will seem like a series of exercises rather than a group where members can share and exchange reactions, feelings, and thoughts. Inexperienced leaders are especially prone to this error, perhaps because they do not fully understand the purpose of the exercise and how to process it, or they fear that members won't have things to say.

Poor Planning of Time

Leaders often plan too much time for activities such as rounds or written exercises. Although the actual exercise usually takes only 1–2 minutes, beginning leaders plan for 5 minutes or more. The processing of these activities may take 10–20 minutes. The flip side of this is also a common mistake—allowing too much time for an activity like a dyad. Some students in sample plans put in a 10- or 15-minute dyad, which is usually far too long. Most dyads are 3–5 minutes. It is important to consider the appropriate time for any activities or exercises. With experience, planning the amount of time for different activities becomes easier.

Poor Planning of the Flow of the Session

A good plan has a reasonable order or flow. Some leaders forget this and plan topics or exercises that are not related to each other. For example, a leader would not want to conduct an exercise that focuses on fun followed by one that focuses on death. Also, leaders sometimes arrange the topics or exercises in a sequence that makes them less beneficial than they could be. For instance, it is a mistake for the leader to plan an exercise where members are providing personal feedback to each other, followed by a discussion of how members see themselves. Rather, the order should be reversed, because it would benefit members more to consider how they see themselves before hearing feedback from others.

Not Planning an Interesting Beginning

Some leaders fail to plan interesting warm-up phases. This is a mistake especially for groups run in institutions—such as prisons or mental hospitals—where members tend to be negative. It can be a mistake to plan a few minutes for opening comments, because members will often offer some complaint about the institution or the program. Leaders will want to plan interesting openings that do not allow negative comments to surface at the beginning. The leader might even

establish that the last few minutes of each session will be available for members to air their complaints.

Allowing Too Much Time for Warm-Up

A common mistake is planning warm-up or introductory activities that last too long. These exercises, although important, can drastically reduce time available for more meaningful, productive work in the middle part of the session. It is *imperative* that the leader plan the group so that the most time is spent on the most important issues. Allowing as much as 15 to 20 minutes for warm-up is usually a mistake, because most people want to move on to new material. It is very important to make sure that the opening is productive and not so long as to bore the members.

Not Allowing Enough Time for Warm-Up

When leaders have much to cover in a session, they sometimes forget to plan for the warm-up phase. Members usually need some time to get focused, which is the purpose of the first few minutes of any group. Groups will vary as to how much time is needed for the beginning phase of the session, but it is important that the leader allot whatever time is needed. In Chapter 5, we discuss the warm-up phase in detail.

Vague Plans

Many beginning leaders plan their groups too vaguely to be of much help. For instance, the leader might plan to deal with the subject of anger and allow 45 minutes for the topic but neglect to plan in detail how to introduce the topic and what exercises and activities to use. The leader who plans well plans how she is going to cover the topic and also gives thought to possible spin-off subjects, such as anger at parents, self-talk and anger, and ways to deal with anger.

Lack of Flexibility

Some leaders rigidly follow their plan even when members have raised issues that are more meaningful and appropriate than those planned. Other leaders fail to recognize when their plan is not working. *It is necessary to be flexible and deviate from a plan whenever it becomes clear that members are not benefiting from it.* Imagine the toll in group commitment and interest in the following scenario.

■ EXAMPLE

The leader has planned two activities to improve family communication for a group of teenagers who live together in a detention center. The members tell the leader how angry they are at two of the residents who are not in the

group. Their anger is due to a stealing and lying incident. Rather than changing the plan and focusing on their immediate needs, the leader forces the members to try the communication-skills activities. They listlessly role-play their mothers and fathers.

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GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

View again video 2.1 where the leader was flexible, in that he had planned to do an exercise but shifted to focusing on group dynamics. Being flexible is essential.

Concluding Comments

Planning consists of two parts—pre-group planning and session planning. Pre-group planning deals with such things as the kind of group, when it meets, how long it meets, and who the members should be. Screening is very important and can be accomplished in a number of ways, including personal interview, written forms, or referral from others.

A leader should plan the beginning, middle, and ending phases of any particular session. Common mistakes regarding planning are not planning, planning too much, not considering how time is allotted, planning too many exercises, and not being flexible. Remember that although we emphasize the importance of having a plan, the effective leader is never a slave to that plan. If a valuable new topic emerges during a session, the leader should alter the plan. If the plan is not working, the leader should abandon it and use a backup plan. The effective leader is always adjusting the plan during the session.

■ ACTIVITIES

1. Write up plans for at least two group sessions using the format of the sample plans. Also write up a brief rationale for why you planned what you did (similar to the paragraphs that followed each of the four sample plans). Leave the plans for a day or two and then review them and see if they need changing. Often they require changes because you see things that don't exactly flow or fit or the designated times are not right.
2. Pick a group that you may lead, plan how many sessions that group will meet, and list all the topics that may be covered during the life of that group.
3. Go back to the plans you wrote and reread the list of common mistakes (pp. 84–88) and see if you made any. We feel that reviewing the common mistakes will help you avoid bad planning.

4. With two or three of your classmates or colleagues, decide on a kind of group to plan such as team building for a sports team, a crisis group after a suicide, or a group on dealing with the holidays. Then have each of you write a plan for the session. Next, get together with two or three others who planned the same group and compare the plans. This will help you to see that there are many ways to approach a group session and some are better than others. If you do this a few times, you will get much better at planning due to hearing all the different ideas from others.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. Review videos 1.1. and 1.2.
   a. Did the leader have a plan in video 1.1?
   b. Did the leader have a plan for video 1.2?
   c. How did the plan help in the overall development of the group?
2. Review videos 2.1 and 2.2. Note how the leader was flexible with his plan. In other words, he had a plan, but something emerged that said he should alter the plan.
3. If you have watched the entire video series, think back on some of the videos where the leader was obviously following a plan (7.1—the leader used fuses; 8.6—the leader used sentence completion; 10.1—the leader used Styrofoam cups; 10.3—the leader used common reading; and 13.3—the leader used WDEP).